

The Complete Guide

Claude Skills

Explained

- » What they are
 - » Why they exist
 - » How to build your own in 5 minutes
-



What are **Claude Skills**?



A folder of instructions

Skills are markdown files Claude reads before tackling a task



Domain expertise on demand

Teach Claude how to write docs, code, design - your way



Reusable across tasks

Write once, use on every matching request automatically

How skills **actually** work

1

You write a SKILL.md file

Plain markdown with instructions, examples, best practices

2

Claude detects the right skill

Based on the task type, Claude finds the matching skill

3

It reads the file before responding

Uses the view tool to load your instructions

4

Output follows your standards

Every response reflects your preferred approach

Anatomy of a Skill File



```
# my-skill / SKILL.md
```

```
---
```

```
name: my-skill
```

```
description: When to use this
```

```
---
```

```
## What this skill does
```

```
Step-by-step instructions...
```

```
## Examples
```

```
Good and bad examples...
```

```
## Rules
```

- ALWAYS include examples
- NEVER skip the description
- Keep instructions concise

Create Your **SKILL.md** File

```
---  
name: email-writer  
description: Use when writing  
            professional emails  
---  
  
# Email Writing Guide  
Always be concise. Lead with  
the ask. Use bullet points.  
Sign off with next steps.
```

Set Up Your **Folder Structure**

```
└─ /mnt/skills/  
    └─ user/  
        └─ email-writer/  
            └─ SKILL.md ← your file  
        └─ code-reviewer/  
            └─ SKILL.md  
        └─ report-writer/  
            └─ SKILL.md
```

Each skill lives in its own folder with a SKILL.md file

Write Great Instructions



Be specific in the description

Claude uses it to know when to trigger your skill



Include good & bad examples

Show what success looks like with concrete samples



Add hard rules clearly

Use "NEVER" and "ALWAYS" for non-negotiable constraints

See it in Action

 /mnt/skills/user/ code-reviewer/SKILL.md

name: code-reviewer

description: Use when asked to
review or audit code files

Rules

- Check for security issues first
- Flag N+1 queries
- Suggest refactors, not rewrites

Now whenever you ask Claude to "review my code", it automatically loads this skill and applies your standards before responding.